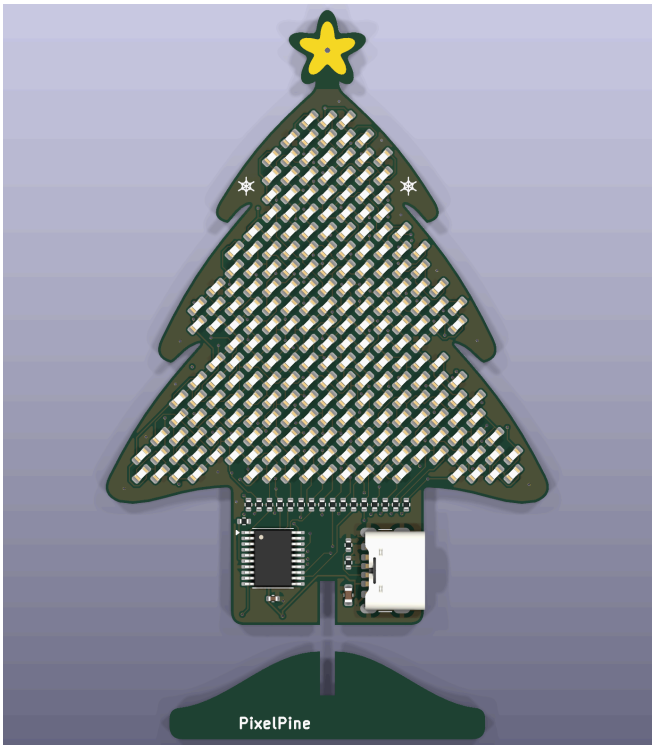
PixelPine — a 7 cm PCB Christmas tree with 240 charlieplexed LEDs

KTE Project 1 · design-for-manufacture study · rev A · 2026-09-23

A chubby, cute, 70 mm tall PCB tree covered in **240 warm-white 0603 LEDs** on a 2.12 mm grid. The LEDs are charlieplexed on 16 pins of a **$0.13 Puya PY32F003** (Cortex-M0+, 64 KB flash) with software PWM. It runs from USB-C and slots into a PCB stand fin. The tree is a character, **Pine**, whose job is showing light shows. He's bad at it: he daydreams, naps, gets grumpy and gets excited to show you things. You interact with him through the capacitive star, which senses hover, tap, pet, press, a front-and-back squeeze and tickles. Landed cost ≈ **€3.2 at 1 000 pcs, €2.0 at 10 000 pcs**; suggested shelf price **€12.90**.

Try Pine in your browser: machmar.github.io/pixelpine (the animation simulator).

Front	Back
	

Deliverables

You asked for	Where
Schematic	`hardware/pixelpine_schematic.pdf` · KiCad 10 project `hardware/pixelpine.kicad_pro` (ERC: 0 errors, 0 warnings)
PCB shape and layout	`hardware/pixelpine.kicad_pcb`: outline, stand fin, all 267 parts (+2 logo marks) placed with nets, silkscreen, CE/WEEE marks, **routed on 2 layers** (Freerouting, then finished by hand in KiCad: GND pour on both layers, 142 vias). DRC: 0 unconnected, schematic parity 0 issues; 2 cosmetic *starved thermal* notes (see the order guide). The LEDs sit in a routing-friendly arrangement: see LED arrangement
BOM (LCSC / JLCPCB)	`docs/bom.md` · JLC upload files `hardware/production/jlc_bom.csv`, `jlc_cpl.csv`
Order files	`hardware/production/`: Gerber + drill zips for the tree (PCB + assembly) and the stand fin (bare PCB), BOM/CPL, 3D previews, and an order guide with every JLC setting and what to check in the placement preview

You asked for	Where
PC app to preview the animations	`simulator/index.html`, live at machmar.github.io/pixelpine (published from `simulator/` by `.github/workflows/pages.yml`): open it in any browser; works offline apart from fonts. Pine runs live: touch his star (hover / click / hold / shift / ctrl / fast clicks) and watch his feelings change. Preview mode plays any show, face or transition. Includes an electrical model of the charlieplex (current sag, PWM depth, refresh, pin current)
Pine: character, faces, transitions, gestures	`docs/animations.md`: behaviour state machine, emotions, 15 light shows, 16 faces, 6 transitions, touch gestures, RAM/flash budget
Market analysis	`docs/market-analysis.md`
EU certification setup	`docs/eu-compliance/`: applicability matrix, EMC test plan, technical file + risk assessment, DoC template, labels and leaflet (EN/CZ)
Final price analysis incl. assembly	`docs/cost-analysis.md`, generated by `docs/cost_model.py`
Connectivity & power consumption	`docs/power-and-connectivity.md`
Firmware fit check	`firmware/sizetest/`: real compile of all shows, faces, brain and drivers for both MCUs. The original CH32V003 overflowed (20.9 KB of 16 KB), so the MCU was switched to the PY32F003F18P6: **17.2 KB of 64 KB flash (27 %), 1.9 KB of 8 KB RAM (23 %)**, built with the Arm GNU Toolchain. See `docs/animations.md`
Design spec	`docs/superpowers/specs/2026-09-23-pixelpine-design.md`
All docs as PDF	`docs/pdf/PixelPine-documentation.pdf`: everything above in one linked PDF (cover, contents), plus one PDF per doc in `docs/pdf/`. Regenerate with `python docs/export_pdfs.py` after editing a doc

Key numbers

LEDs	240 × XL-1608WWC-06 (0603, 2500–3000 K) at 45°, 2.12 mm pitch
MCU	Puya PY32F003F18P6 (TSSOP-20, pinout 1, 24 MHz internal oscillator): 16 charlieplex lines (incl. SWD pins and BOOT0) + ADC touch star (PA7) + NRST; SWD programming
Character	6 emotions (energy, focus, mood, annoyance, excitement, bond in flash), 16 faces, 6 transitions
Parts	263 placements, 8 line items, 552 SMD joints, single-sided
PCB	2-layer FR-4 1.6 mm, LF-HASL, JLC standard process (0.10 mm tracks and spaces at the narrowest, 0.3 / 0.4 mm vias); 1658 track segments (1991 mm), 142 vias, GND pour on both layers, 0 unrouted. Tree 50.5 × 70 mm, stand fin 36 × 10 mm
Supply	USB-C 5 V, 3–12 mA typical (≈ 7 mA average), 19 mA max → ≤ 0.1 W
Light	≈ 2 lm total, so outside the EU light-source ecodesign/energy-label scope
Pin current	≤ 16.2 mA per GPIO by design (20 mA rated)
PWM	8-bit binary-code modulation, 16 phases, 122 Hz refresh
CE route	EMC 2014/30/EU (EN IEC 55015 + EN 61547) + RoHS; GPSR, WEEE, PPWR, REACH obligations

LED arrangement

The 240 LED positions are a fixed 2.12 mm grid, but *which* anode/cathode pair sits at which position is a free choice, and it decides whether the board can be routed at all. The first version interleaved the pairs (`anode = n mod 16`), which leaves every one of the 480 LED pads as an island of its own, and Freerouting stalled with 76 connections still open after 87 minutes.

The 45° LEDs form a "brick" lattice with only ~0.55 mm between neighbouring pads. If two neighbouring pads are on the same line net, a tiny F.Cu bridge joins them for free, so a net can be a few big copper islands instead of 30 loose pads. `hardware/scripts/optimize_leds.py` (simulated annealing, C core in `optimize_leds.c`) arranges the 240 pairs for exactly that: 480 separate pads became 141 islands, only the links between islands need real wiring, and the board

routes on **2 layers** in about 2 minutes (it also stopped needing the 4 layers that the old arrangement was thought to need). The result is `hardware/led_assignment.json`, committed; `geometry.py` reads it, so the schematic, PCB, simulator map and firmware tables all follow from it. Every LED keeps the same orientation; the optimiser can also turn LEDs round by 180° (`--flip`) for ~15 % fewer islands, but that wasn't needed.

Side effect: neighbouring LEDs now sometimes share an anode line (17 % of the LED pairs closer than 3.2 mm, against 6 % with the old interleaving), so a lit blob loads some scan phases harder than before. The numbers are in `docs/power-and-connectivity.md`.

Regenerating the hardware

> **Since 2026-10-01 the board is finished by hand in KiCad** (GND pour, extra vias). `build_all.py` would regenerate it from the scripts and drop those edits, so it now stops unless you pass `--regenerate`. For order files run `export_gerbers.py` (KiCad's Python) and `export_fab.py`; see `hardware/production/README.md`.

Everything in `hardware/` was generated from one geometry module, so it stays consistent:

```
python hardware/scripts/build_all.py
```

`geometry.py` (outline, LED grid, charlieplex map from `led_assignment.json`) → `gen_footprints.py` → `gen_sch.py` (+ ERC, netlist check) → `gen_pcb.py` (KiCad's bundled Python) → `route.py` (Freerouting, ~2-5 min; if connections stay open it routes again from scratch, up to 4 runs) → DRC and parity → 3D renders → JLC BOM/CPL. It also refreshes `simulator/led_map.js`, so the simulator always shows the real LED positions. After editing the outline, run `python hardware/scripts/geometry.py --search` and paste the new pitch into `GRID_PITCH`, then `python hardware/scripts/optimize_leds.py` (needs a C compiler, 10–20 min) to re-arrange the LEDs for the new grid. The firmware's per-LED tables come from the same map: `python firmware/sizetest/build.py`.

Open items before ordering

Order files are ready: `hardware/production/README.md`. At order time, check LCSC stock for the 240 LEDs per board and look at the LED polarity and U1 pin 1 in JLC's placement preview.

1. **Firmware, once boards arrive**: the real firmware grows out of `firmware/sizetest/py32f003/`, then touch thresholds and LED brightness get tuned on hardware.

Done: PCB routed on 2 layers (LED arrangement optimised for it, DRC clean), manufacturer name, address (Jehličková 240, 240 24 Stromečkov: made up for the school project, replace it with the registered address for a real product) and e-mail on the product, U1 and J1 placement orientation checked, MCU choice final (PY32F003F18P6, kept over the cheaper F002A for firmware-update headroom).